

Women's Specialists of Clear Lake

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Postpartum Depression (PPD)

You are not alone — PPD is common, treatable, and not your fault

WHAT IS PPD?

Postpartum depression is a mood disorder affecting **1 in 5 new mothers**. It is caused by the dramatic hormonal drop after delivery combined with sleep deprivation, physical recovery, and the emotional demands of new parenthood. PPD is a *medical condition* — not a character flaw or weakness.

BABY BLUES VS. PPD

- **Baby Blues** — affects 70–80% of mothers; tearfulness, mood swings, anxiety starting day 2–3, resolves by 2 weeks
- **PPD** — more severe, lasts >2 weeks, starts within 1 year of delivery, interferes with function
- **Postpartum Psychosis** — rare emergency; hallucinations, confusion, call 911

SYMPTOMS OF PPD

- Persistent sadness, emptiness, or hopelessness
- Loss of interest in activities you enjoyed
- Trouble bonding with your baby
- Excessive worry or anxiety about baby's safety
- Difficulty sleeping (even when baby sleeps)
- Changes in appetite (eating too much or too little)
- Feeling like a bad mother
- Thoughts of harming yourself or your baby

RISK FACTORS

- History of depression, anxiety, or bipolar disorder
- PPD in a previous pregnancy
- Lack of social support or partner support
- Financial stress or relationship problems
- Difficult or traumatic birth
- NICU admission or infant health problems
- History of thyroid disorder
- Unplanned or unwanted pregnancy

TREATMENT — IT WORKS!

- **Therapy** — CBT and interpersonal therapy are highly effective
- **SSRIs** — sertraline (Zoloft), paroxetine — safe in breastfeeding **RX**
- **SNRIs** — venlafaxine, duloxetine **RX**
- **Brexanolone (Zulresso)** — IV infusion, FDA approved for PPD **RX**
- Peer support groups (Postpartum Support International)
- Sleep, self-care, accepting help from others

We screen using the Edinburgh Postnatal Depression Scale (EPDS) at your postpartum visits. Score of ≥10 triggers a care conversation.

HOW TO GET HELP

- Tell your OB or midwife honestly about your feelings
- **Postpartum Support International:** 1-800-944-4773
- **PSI Helpline:** Text HOME to 741741
- Ask your partner or a trusted person to call for you if needed
- Seek help early — PPD responds well to treatment

🚨 SEEK IMMEDIATE HELP IF YOU HAVE THOUGHTS OF HARMING YOURSELF OR YOUR BABY

Call 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline) · Text HOME to 741741 · Call 911 or go to your nearest ER. Postpartum psychosis is a medical emergency — symptoms include hallucinations, confusion, paranoia, or rapidly changing mood. Do not leave the mother alone. Call 911.

⚠️ CALL YOUR DOCTOR IF YOU EXPERIENCE

- ⚠️ Sadness or emptiness that won't go away after 2 weeks
- ⚠️ Feeling like your baby would be better off without you
- ⚠️ Not eating or caring for yourself
- ⚠️ Rage, irritability, or anger that feels uncontrollable
- ⚠️ Unable to sleep even when baby sleeps
- ⚠️ Panic attacks or severe anxiety
- ⚠️ Feeling disconnected from your baby
- ⚠️ Baby Blues worsening rather than improving

💚 You Are a Wonderful Mother — Please Ask for Help

Reaching out for help is one of the bravest and most loving things you can do for yourself and your baby. PPD is not a sign that you don't love your child — it's a medical condition that responds beautifully to treatment. You deserve to feel well. Let us help you get there.